Blockchain for Impact Funding Evidence Map: Project Objectives and Pilot Summary

To: GSR Foundation leadership | From: Michael Cooper, Research Director, Metagov (mike@metagov.org · Telegram: MCooperResearch)

What we are asking

We ask GSR leadership to approve a four-week pilot that tests the Evidence Map method on 20 to 30 public cases. The results will show whether the full exercise, covering 800+ use cases, is worth funding.

Objectives of the full project

The Evidence Map is a structured, public overview of blockchain-based impact projects supported by GSR and its partners. It has four objectives:

- **Purpose and design:** show what these projects are trying to achieve and how they are delivered.
- **Progress:** show which projects move beyond the pilot stage and which never do.
- **Evidence and results:** grade the strength of the evidence behind reported results and how well projects met their objectives.
- **Gaps:** identify the evidence gaps that matter most for future Blockchain for Good funding.

These objectives translate into seven draft research questions. They ask about projects' objectives and sectors; their implementation models; how far they advanced; the quality of evidence (operational measures only, or social outcomes); how well they met their objectives; whether blockchain added value over simpler alternatives; and where the key gaps are. Categories and definitions will be finalised in the taxonomy developed during the pilot.

The pilot: four weeks, public sources only

Michael Cooper will use an LLM to analyse 20 to 30 public cases from Mercy Corps Ventures, the UNICEF Venture Fund and the Filecoin Foundation. To check consistency, two different LLMs will grade each case independently. The pilot has two purposes: to test the method, and to decide whether scaling up is worthwhile.

- **Week 1:** Select cases across use cases and outcomes, including some that stalled; agree the research question with GSR.
- **Week 2:** Draft the taxonomy and five-level evidence scale, add a deployment status for each case, and grade the cases.
- **Week 3:** Compare the two LLMs' grades, check what happened after each pilot, and test whether evidence grades predict scaling.
- **Week 4:** Share a findings memo with GSR, and decide together whether to scale up.

How the pilot informs the decision

Pilot metric	Proposed threshold
1. Agreement between the two LLMs on evidence grades (Cohen's kappa)	0.7 or higher
2. Cases that can be fully graded from public sources	80% or more
3. Cases that fit no category in the taxonomy	10% or fewer
4. Cases whose post-pilot status can be confirmed	75% or more

We propose proceeding to the full project if at least four of the five thresholds are met and the method can be fixed without redesigning the taxonomy or evidence scale. The pilot will also report whether stronger evidence goes with scaling, and how many claims held up. GSR has final authority to approve or decline scaling up, based on its own criteria.

Team and next steps

Michael Cooper, Research Director at Metagov, will lead the work given his expertise in blockchain applications in international development/humanitarian applications and evidence synthesis/decision support (see his work with Metagov, MCC, USAID, FCDO and UNICEF). A possible follow-on project, the Blockchain Funding Kitemark, would use the Evidence Map's findings to help non-technical funders judge whether blockchain-based aid projects are credible.